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VENTURE



The perfect pitch: This
NEA partner says every
founder should answer
these 5 questions



IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Most founders eventually have to pitch venture firms in hopes of raising capital. Tiffany Luck, a partner at [NEA](#), took the stage at TechCrunch's All Stage event in Boston to answer how to craft the perfect pitch.

"I like to think of a VC pitch as your initial way for assessing founder-ness for it," she told the crowd before diving into her presentation. One of the most important slides to have in a pitch is "The What," she said, meaning, "The What' are you building." That's followed by "The Why" you are the right person for the job and why you have a unique solution. But there's another Why, too: "Why' is now the perfect time to do it."

Then there is "The Who," she continued. "Who have you recruited to do this crazy thing with?" And finally, "The How."

"How are you going to get there? How are you getting there today? How will you get there over time?" she said.

Then, of course, "some sense of numbers," she added, saying that part depends on what state a company is trying to fundraise for — pre-seed, seed, Series A, and so forth. "These are just meant to be the fundamental basics."

Setting the stage

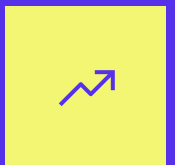
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As Luck explained, “The What” sets the stage, telling the investor what the problem is, how it affects people, followed by what solutions exist today and where lies room for disruption.

Showcasing a product demo during “The What” is a good idea, she said, and that a lot of investors love product demos. “If you think a picture is worth 1,000 words, I think a demo is worth 1,000 hours,” she said. “When you see the product, you actually get it quickly.”

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Luck said there are two different “Whys” every founder should address. First, there is the deeper Why, where a founder goes into their origin story and explains their unique perspective on a solution.

Obsession is key here, she said, adding that investors want to see and understand that a founder is completely consumed by a problem and solution. This passion is what will keep everyone motivated to keep building, she said.

Following this is the “Why now,” which means going into the market dynamics and readiness.

“It’s telling the story of why the market is ready for what you have or what you’re building,” she said.

The Why now leads into “The Who,” where the founder is expected to talk about the team they’ve assembled, how everyone’s skills complement each other, and why everyone is obsessed with the mission of the product.

“The shared conviction piece is really important,” Luck said. “It’s ‘how are you all envisioning the future together?’”

“The How,” is where a founder is supposed to talk about “milestones.”

Here, she said, investors want to know what the minimum viable product (MVP) is. Who are the early users? And what feedback is the product getting from them so far?

“And again, explain where you are today. Where are you going? What have you learned?” she asked, listing off the questions.

Talking about pivoting, if necessary, is also good here.

Luck noted that she often talks to founders who pivoted early or at some point in their journey. It helps investors learn more about the early phases of a company, of “where not to go, what not to do, and it will help with the rest of the journey,” she said.

For the love of numbers

Finally, she weighed in on the importance of numbers.

“Investors do love numbers,” she said. “I think a lot of the important numbers also involve storytelling.” Here, investors want to know about the market size and any traction a product might have. “Why do customers love this product? Why do you imagine that it’s not only going to grow, but grow sustainably in a way that has great retention?”

She likes to see a company talk about how much cash it’s burning through, and what the runway looks like. The most important thing, though, is the *ask*: how much a founder is looking to raise this round and what they will do with the money.

All together, the Who, What, How, and (two) Whys serve as a starting point, helping founders as they go forth on the entrepreneurship journey.

“Founding a company is like extreme sports,” she said, likening it to climbing Everest in particular. “You’re going up on milestones, different camps. You’re encountering challenges, you’re weathering storms, and you know, eventually you’re trying to make it to the top, to the summit.”

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Latin American founders see VC funding drop as investors retreat from underrepresented cohorts

Dominic-Madori
Davis

— 10:00 AM PDT · October 28,
2022

IMAGE CREDITS: KLAUS VEDFELT / GETTY IMAGES

The latest Crunchbase [data](#) shows that Latin American-founded companies in the United States raised \$250 million out of the \$39.85 billion allocated in venture funds in the U.S. this Q3 — or about 0.63%.¹ The Q3 sum is a sharp decrease from the \$2.3 billion the cohort raised in Q3 last year and a dramatic decline from the \$1.3 billion raise in Q2 this year.

In total, 1.5% of all venture dollars so far in 2022 have been allocated to Latin American-founded

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companies, a drop from 2.5% last year, according to the Crunchbase analysis.

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to them amid economic downturns — and those people tend to be white men.

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The somewhat encouraging news is that funding for early-stage Latin American-founded companies is on pace to exceed 2021's total; much of the decline that we see in the above numbers came from a decrease in late-stage financing. The reality remains that women and minorities are not faring well right now when it comes to raising VC, and promises of change have dissipated. Last year, Latin American-founded U.S. companies raised \$8.5 billion. Through the end of Q3 2022, that number stands at \$2.7 billion, meaning it won't even come close to passing last year's record-breaking sum.

"It's disappointing but not surprising that funding for Latino founders is down this much," [Miranda Perez](#), the program coordinator of the [HBCU Founders Initiative](#), told TechCrunch, adding that investors need to take much more responsibility when it comes to "deploying opportunities for the advancement of marginalized communities."

[Adrian Mendoza](#), the founder of Mendoza Ventures, told TechCrunch he anticipated a drop in funding for Latin American founders, citing how investors often avoid diverse and women founders during economic downturns because they are seen as “risky to the status quo funds.”



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“Now is the time for LPs to step up and invest in Latino-owned funds that can deploy to those Latino founders that are building amazing businesses,” Mendoza continued, adding that the influx will help change the face of venture capital and the overall tech ecosystem.

[Javi Park](#), the CEO and co-founder of [Reamp.xyz](#), noted that out of the 26 fundraising calls he’s had so far, he’s only met with one investment associate who identifies as Latin American.

“By nature, we tend to be more helpful to those who look like us,” Park told TechCrunch. “This is why we need more [Latinx](#) folks in these roles.”

Mendoza agreed. “Now is the time to start our own communities to step up and fund these Latino founders and funds,” he said. “If we want to control where the capital flows, it has to come from Latino LPs to Latino funds, to Latino founders. This is how we control the capital stack and make a real difference.”

It’s been [well reported](#) that investors are leaving money on the table by excluding minority founders from both managerial opportunities and funding prospects. As the numbers remain inconsistent, there is no solid way to predict when venture capitalists will care about those outside their comfortable pattern match. What is known, though, is that the industry is running everyone around in circles regarding the conversation around equitable funding.

Perez put it perfectly: For the publicist typing away another press release on racial unity on behalf of whatever firm, or for the investors at the end of their keyboard getting ready-set to type a Twitter thread in solidarity with the marginalized, she said, “Talk less. Do more.”

Editor’s note: Crunchbase provided TechCrunch with Latin American funding data for the U.S. market in Q3. However, because Crunchbase News reporting aggregates overall U.S. results with Canadian numbers, we had to go afield to get the correct denominator for our calculation. We turned to Q3 U.S. venture capital aggregates from PitchBook and CB Insights for that figure. To reach it, we used the midpoint of PitchBook and CB Insights Q3 data, contrasted with the Crunchbase Latin American figure for U.S. venture results in the third quarter. In our view, this is the fairest and clearest way to parse available data.

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Debunking the myths of why venture investors don't fund diverse startups

Dominic-Madori
Davis

— 1:00 PM PST · January 20,
2023

People can never land on a word to explain what is happening to women and minorities within venture. Are such founders overlooked or undersought? Underestimated *and* underrepresented? Marginalized? Discriminated against? Or just ignored?

The excuses used to justify these sobriquets are equally scattered. Women received just [1.9% of all venture capital](#) funds last year because they are only building beauty and wellness companies; there is a lack of a proven track record; it's too early, they are too risky, and there is a pipeline problem. Maybe she'll get married, have a family and leave the business behind.

And Black founders raised [1% of venture funds](#) because there aren't enough of them pitching; they are a minority of the population and thus deserve a minority of the funds; their products and markets tap into something [only their community](#) can relate to; there isn't enough traction, they aren't qualified; or, as [one Twitter user](#) wrote, they aren't "male, pale and from Yale."

Ah, yes, this explains it all. Women are too emotional to run companies. One female founder told TechCrunch she heard an investor say he wouldn't invest in a woman-founded company because "she was annoying."

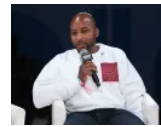
Men, on the other hand, are not annoying. They are competent and qualified, and, as we all well know, sexism and racial discrimination [went poof](#) after the civil rights and third-wave feminism movements. Since then, decisions toward people of color and women have been based purely on quantitative and provable facts. *Obviously.*

Indeed, investors' fact-based due diligence often leaves out that women-founded companies [have higher returns](#) than male-founded ones. The rest of

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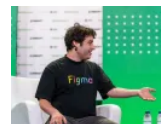
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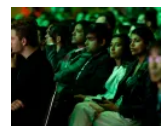
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the data regarding bias in the venture industry is so nebulous that it's hard to call much of it out. Without transparency, it's difficult to determine exactly how many people of color and women are pitching, thus making it hard to assess how disproportionate funding to these groups truly is. There is a way, though, to pick apart some common misconceptions.

For one, women ([especially Black women](#)) are [more likely](#) to start a business than men (and [continue to open](#) companies in increasing amounts), meaning the idea that there aren't enough women to invest in is simply untrue.



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Many also believe women are starting companies mainly in consumer tech, beauty and wellness, but according to the 2017 and 2018 business surveys [conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau](#), they are most likely to be concentrated in the healthcare and social assistance industries, followed by retail and food.

But last year, [a sizable amount](#) of the capital given to women-founded companies was to those that launched within the software industry, per PitchBook. In previous years, most funding to women oscillated between those in software and those launching in pharmaceuticals and biotechnology, where [the number of female entrepreneurs](#) is steadily increasing.

Another stereotype is that women launch “easy businesses,” not something “serious” like “deep tech” — as if any business is leisurely to start. Even then, though, is that enough? Lux Capital General Partner [Deena Shakir](#) noted that back in 1995, biochemist Katalin Karikó couldn’t [raise money](#) for her mRNA vaccine.

“Fast-forward to 2021, without her research, there would have been no hope for the COVID-19 vaccines,” Shakir told TechCrunch.

Even if women were only starting beauty companies, was Glossier not hailed as one of the most innovative direct-to-consumer businesses to spawn from the millennial generation? Recreating that billion-dollar success is what investors claim to look for when it comes to funding new founders, and that rush mentality led to a splash of capital in industries such as web3 and crypto. At least four Black women have been able to scale unicorns: Rihanna, makeup mogul Pat McGrath, physician Iman Abuzeid and Cityblock Health’s Toyin Ajayi. All of their businesses are within the sectors of either beauty or health.

Yet, women and people of color do not build products that “others” want, remember? Black founders, [a group responsible](#) for the invention of the potato chip, traffic signal, automatic elevator and folding chair, have not proven themselves as viable entrepreneurs, and neither have women,

[who created](#) the fire escape, the dishwasher and Monopoly, for that matter.

Black founders have recalled pitching beauty products, for example, only to be told that the industry wasn't big enough; when these founders pointed out that the sector has multibillion-dollar potential, investors suddenly said they didn't understand the market well enough to be of help.

At the same time, women are also often told they are either riskier to bet on or that they are more risk averse than men. Research conducted by the Psychology of Women Quarterly found, at least in the workplace, women are [not necessarily more risk avoidant](#) than men, but that they are punished more for taking risks.

“Female-founded companies in the U.S. have increased by over five times in the last 15 years, so if anything, women are taking more risks when it comes to starting a business,” [Emma Bates](#), the founder of Diem, told TechCrunch. “It’s worth noting that the way appetite for ‘risk’ is measured in previous workplace studies is often biased toward male-heavy risky activities, like ‘likelihood to go skydiving’ or [...] ‘would you ride a motorcycle without wearing a helmet?’”

Questions are another way investors subtly screen a candidate. Harvard Business Review [found that](#) women and men are indeed asked different questions by investors: Men are asked more questions about potential gains, while women are more often questioned about potential losses. Even the criteria by which investors judge women is a little skewed. DocSend [found last year](#) that when looking at the pitch decks of men, investors often spend more time analyzing the product. When it comes to women, they spend more time looking for who's on the team.

Pointing to this, Christie Pitts, a general partner at Backstage Capital, said that many of the conclusions investors make about women and people of color are actually rooted in their own behavior rather than anything factual. Many investors also like to say that there aren't enough women, for example, studying STEM or that they simply aren't interested in technology. But more women [are entering](#) STEM fields, and though the industry is still dominated by men, the lack of women has more to do with barriers to entry rather than a lack of interest.

Nonetheless, there is always talent to pull from; for example, [nearly 40%](#) of Meta's workforce is women. Saying that there are not enough women in STEM reveals an investor who hasn't sought out the alleged pipeline before calling it a problem.

Then there exist strange loops. For one, women and people of color are ostracized for not raising family and friend rounds, even though the racial and gender wealth gap leaves these two groups at a disadvantage regarding access to substantial friends and family money. Or, investors claim they're just nipping it in the bud. [Heather Hopkins](#), who is building the dating app Hulah, said an investor once told her that they would love to invest in her company, but with her being a woman, they were "worried about the difficulties" she would face raising the next round.

[Kerry Schrader](#), the Black female co-founder of the human resource company Mixtroz, said white male investors overlooked her two decades of experience in HR and told her that it would look better if she, then 52, stepped aside and let her 28-year-old daughter and co-founder helm the company. A 2018 study from [Kellogg Insight](#) found that the average tech founder is 41, and the average CEO of a Fortune 500 company [is at least](#) 57. Meanwhile, [Ebony Jazzmine](#), a 25-year-old edtech

founder, said investors tell her she is too young to start a company.

She recalled they once brought up that it's almost time for her to get married and have a family; then, she'll have no time to start or run a business. Never mind that Elon Musk has fathered [10 children](#) or that Larry Page and Sergey Brin were 25 when they founded Google.

Actually, most entrepreneurs [are married women](#). It is true that having children does change the trajectory of a woman's career, though it could be argued that is because of abysmal parental leave policies in the U.S. If women were provided with the resources needed to care for a child at an affordable price, then the relationship between a woman and her career wouldn't be so fraught after she becomes a mother.

Arguably, if an investor is so worried that a woman couldn't run a business after starting a family, they would help her set up a company with proper parental leave and structure the business in such a way that it could function in her absence. It's long been touted anyway that working mothers make [for some of the best entrepreneurs](#) because they have extensive experience in juggling responsibilities and managing egos.

[Suelin Chen](#), the co-founder of Cake, said she has so many "war" stories of men telling her that mothers can't start businesses or that being pregnant was "like kryptonite" to investors. "You can't say you support women in tech without supporting moms," Chen, who has raised nearly \$9 million in funding and is the mother of two children, told TechCrunch.

On that note, investors also like to compare women to their own wives and mothers, usually as a way to insult them. [Janice Taylor](#), the founder of Ahava

Healing, said an investor once told her that if “my mom doesn’t understand web3, I’m not convinced you could know it either.”

“All last year, I was raising money for my crypto music company,” she told TechCrunch. “It was like 1950, and the misogyny and bias were the worst in web3.”

This goes into the conscious and unconscious bias part of an investor analyzing an individual and their company. A good excuse is always to say that a founder doesn’t have enough traction without exactly identifying what type of traction is sought or that a product is too niche, as if those markets aren’t scaleable; as if more than [50 million Squishmallows](#) haven’t been sold for at least \$19.99 a pop.

Investors know that by excluding women and people of color, they are leaving money on the table and, in a way, [stifling entrepreneurship](#) for generations to come. In a perfect world, as venture becomes more mainstream, the structures holding it in place must configure themselves to let in those long excluded. Realistically, one investor [broke it down](#) to Servane Mouazan clear as day: “Because Me Too was four years ago, and BLM two years ago, we’re looking for something else now.”

Looks like marginalized founders just have to wait for their plight to be trendy again.

This piece was updated to reflect the title of Lux Capital General Partner Deena Shakir.

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